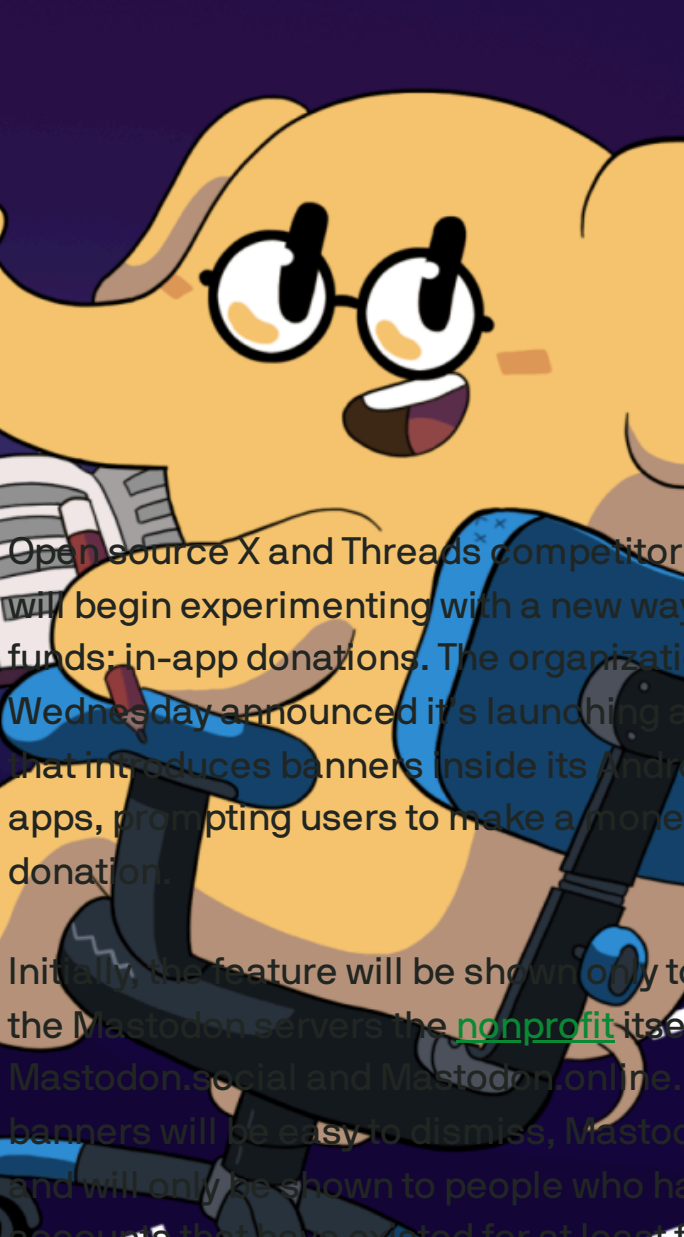


Advertisement

SOCIAL



Open source X rival
Mastodon begins raising
funds with new in-app
donation feature



Open source X and Threads competitor Mastodon will begin experimenting with a new way to raise funds: in-app donations. The organization on Wednesday announced it's launching a campaign that introduces banners inside its Android and iOS apps, prompting users to make a monetary donation.

Initially, the feature will be shown only to those on the Mastodon servers the [nonprofit](#) itself operates, Mastodon.social and Mastodon.online. These banners will be easy to dismiss, Mastodon says, and will only be shown to people who have accounts that have existed for at least four weeks. The organization promises that it won't continually prompt users to donate, either.

IMAGE CREDITS: MASTODON

Such campaigns can work well for nonprofit organizations at scale. Wikimedia Foundation, for example, brings in the [majority](#) of its funding from individual donors, including those who donate through the pop-up banners that occasionally appear on Wikipedia. However, Mastodon has a much smaller user base: 8.1 million [registered](#) accounts, and fewer than 1 million monthly active users. Still, the banners could encourage people who haven't actively sought out ways to contribute to now do so, as it makes the process more seamless as an in-app feature.

Mastodon says it will later expand the campaign to the web and, if successful, make it available to all

TEC DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

other Mastodon instances. The latter would allow individual server admins to receive direct support from their own users, which could help keep them operational.

As an open, decentralized social media platform, Mastodon faces challenges when it comes to financial support. Unlike Meta and X, which are supported by ads, Mastodon [so far has relied largely on](#) user donations from Patreon. It has also accepted a handful of donations from open source-focused funds and foundations over the years.

In [2023](#), Mastodon raised €545,000 in total donations, up 65% year-over-year, but its Patreon donor base dropped nearly 23% to 7,400. (Its 2024 report is not out yet.) That decline could have pushed it to look into more aggressive fundraising tactics, especially as competition from Meta and newcomers like the VC-backed startup Bluesky is growing.

“We know that collecting money can present complexities and questions,” a Mastodon [blog post](#) stated. “We’d like to figure out how to do this well, together with the community. This is not a corporate fundraising campaign: it’s an effort to secure the future of a more ethical and independent social web.”

Topics: [Apps](#) [Apps](#) [Fundraising](#) [Mastodon](#)

[open social](#) [open source](#) [Social](#)

[social media](#)

- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren’t even dating apps



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING



IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

SOCIAL



Mastodon sees a boost from the 'X exodus,' too, founder says

Sarah Perez — 10:44 AM PST · November 18, 2024

Decentralized social network [Mastodon](#) is also seeing some uplift from [the X "exodus,"](#) founder Eugen Rochko [shared](#) on the platform just ahead of the weekend. While the [Twitter-like startup Bluesky](#) has been capturing headlines and attention for its

Newsletters

[See More](#) ↗

[rapid adoption](#) among former X users, a smaller group has apparently turned to the open source networking platform [Mastodon](#), which has seen downloads increase by 47% on iOS and its monthly active users grow to 894,000 across all Mastodon servers, Rochko says.

In a post on Mastodon, the founder and CEO noted that official app downloads were growing. In

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so

Latest
Startups
Venture
Apple

Security
AI
Apps



Events
Podcasts
Newsletters

startup route by raising money from outside investors. The company last month closed on a [\\$15 million Series A](#), led by Blockchain Capital. Bluesky plans to generate revenue via [subscriptions](#) at some later point and by providing other paid services, like [access to custom domains](#). For some former X users now choosing Mastodon, Bluesky's obligation to chase venture-sized returns is a non-starter.

Despite Mastodon's recent "X exodus"-fueled adoption, the latest activity still falls below late 2022 levels, when [Mastodon had gotten an early boost](#) thanks to other Twitter drama, including the product changes Elon Musk introduced around [moderation](#) and [paid verification](#). As of November 2022, Mastodon had surpassed 1 million monthly

Subscribe

agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



active users and was seeing “thousands” of registrations per hour, it said at the time.

Things have slowed since for the X alternative, which today has north of [7.6 million](#) total users compared with Bluesky’s now more than [19.4 million](#), which is up from [16 million](#) just days ago.

Despite the threat from Bluesky, Rochko says that the fediverse — or the open social web powered by the ActivityPub protocol that underpins Mastodon and newer efforts like Meta’s [Threads](#) — is the “long game.” (Threads’ 275 million+ users are not counted among the [10.9+ million broader fediverse](#) users because the platform isn’t fully federated yet.)

TC

Techcrunch event

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech —

grab your ticket now and save up to \$675
before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

“I spent 25% of my life working on Mastodon. It’s kind of wild when you think about it,” Rochko [mused on Mastodon](#). “When I started, Google+ was still around. We’re doing what one of the most resourceful companies in the world couldn’t do. It’s not easy. It’s always easier to just build A Website, then slap some ads on it,” he said, likely referencing Threads’ plan to be [ad-supported](#). “But the fediverse is the long game.”

Topics: [Apps](#) [Apps](#) [Bluesky](#) [Mastodon](#) [Social](#)
[social media](#) [social networking](#) [Twitter](#)



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [Email](#) [LinkedIn](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

APPS



Mastodon founder touts Threads' federation, saying it makes his X rival 'a far more attractive option'

Sarah Perez — 7:44 AM PST · December 14, 2023

Mastodon founder Eugen Rochko lauds Threads' entry into the decentralized social media space, [saying the move will make Mastodon](#) — the open source Twitter/X rival — “a far more attractive option.” Mastodon's app, which is powered by the decentralized social networking protocol ActivityPub, has gained more attention in the wake of Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter, a network that's been since renamed X to reflect Musk's ambitions to turn the microblogging platform into an everything app encompassing creators, payments, video, live audio and shopping.

Those unhappy with Twitter's changes have been scoping out other platforms, including Mastodon, an open source alternative, as well as challengers from other startups like Spill, Spoutible, Post, Bluesky and others. But with Instagram's entry into the “Twitter clone” space, things have shifted once again. Now there's a Twitter alternative with Meta's sizable resources behind it, which helped it to grow to [nearly 100 million monthly active users](#) only three

Latest in Apps

[See More](#)

APPS



The Browser Company launches a \$20 monthly subscription for its AI-powered browser

Ivan Mehta - 2 hours ago

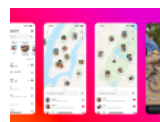
AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 14 hours ago

APPS



Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 18 hours ago

months post-launch. Mastodon today has [just 1.5 million monthly actives](#), for comparison.

More importantly for Mastodon, Meta committed to integrating Threads with ActivityPub, meaning users would be able to find and follow both Mastodon and Threads users across both services. While many expected that integration wouldn't arrive until early 2024, Meta surprised everyone by announcing yesterday that it [would begin testing ActivityPub integration](#).

“Making Threads interoperable will give people more choice over how they interact and it will help content reach more people. I’m pretty optimistic about this,” said Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg [in a post on Threads](#).

Zuckerberg didn't explain how the integration would work, but Rochko cleared up the confusion with a post on Mastodon where he said federation — meaning the connection of Threads to the wider group of servers running decentralized social apps — was “one-way for now.” That means Mastodon users can follow “a few selected” Threads user profiles — [like Instagram head Adam Mosseri](#) — on Mastodon, but the reverse isn't yet true.

Threads users' profiles on Mastodon weren't backfilled with their older posts before the integration went live. Instead, the profiles will feature posts from this point forward while a message instructs you that “older posts from other servers are not displayed.” A link to “browse more on the original profile” will take users over to Threads instead.

Rochko has been largely positive about having the tech giant embrace ActivityPub and decentralized social media, [having earlier said](#), “The fact that large platforms are adopting ActivityPub is not only validation of the movement towards decentralized

social media, but a path forward for people locked into these platforms to switch to better providers.”

TC

Techcrunch event

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

The Mastodon founder also downplayed concerns that Meta’s entry could lead to an “[embrace-extend-extinguish](#)” situation for the ActivityPub protocol — a reference to how big companies enter markets with existing standards, then extend those standards with proprietary capabilities to squash competition.

“...even if Threads abandoned ActivityPub down the line, where we would end up is exactly where we are now,” Rochko pointed out in [a blog post this summer](#).

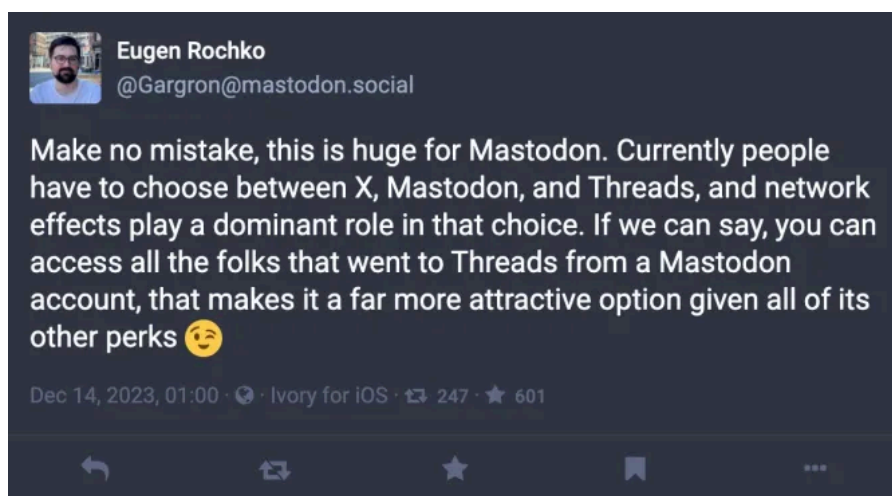


IMAGE CREDITS: EUGEN ROCHKO ON MASTODON

As the integration goes live, Rochko touted the move as “exciting,” and “huge for Mastodon,” saying in [a post on the platform](#) that it’s a “step towards the interoperable social web that we’ve been advocating for.”

In addition, [he points out](#) that having access to all Threads users from a Mastodon account makes the app more attractive, considering its other perks.

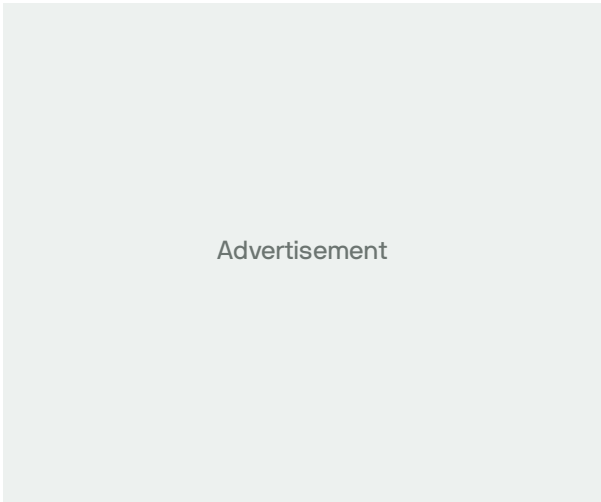
That same argument is being made by the Mastodon third-party client, Mammoth, [backed by Mozilla](#), which believes that its app will offer a competitive user interface that will be more approachable for newcomers to decentralized social media, and a viable alternative to Threads, including for those users who don’t want to create an account with Meta. While Threads has distanced itself from news, [saying it would not “amplify” news](#) on its platform, [Mammoth has embraced news partnerships and curation](#), which it expects may appeal to those leaving Twitter/X for other apps.

With Threads’ integration into Mastodon’s ecosystem, users will have more choice in how they want to engage with Threads users and

content, including by accessing those accounts from an app of their choosing.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Apps](#) [decentralized](#) [Mastodon](#)

[open source](#) [Social](#) [social media](#) [Threads](#)



Sarah Perez
Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [M](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article

• ● ● ● ●

